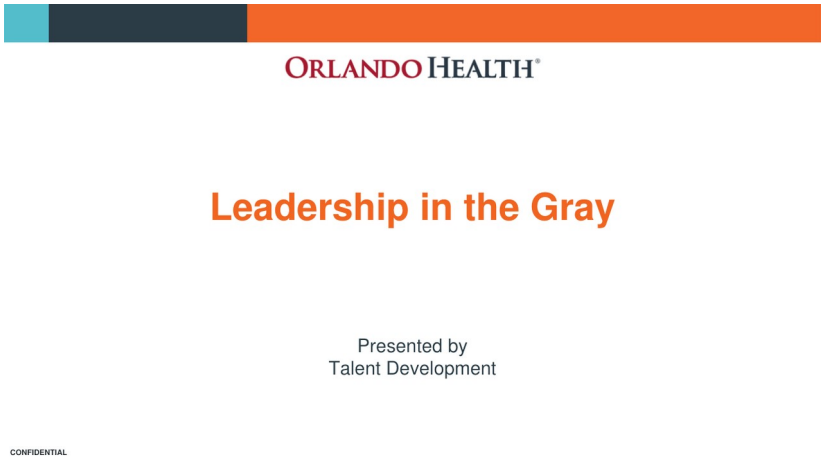
Leadership in the Gray

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Leadership in the Gray



TIMING: 1:00 | 0:00–1:00

SESSION: Target 13 minutes, including brief discussion. For 12 minutes, take one response per prompt. For 15 minutes, allow one additional example.

SAY:

Welcome to today's Nurse Leader Huddle. You may be arriving with a full schedule and a decision still waiting for your attention. Today we will use a simple process for making a responsible next move when priorities compete and information is incomplete.

ASK:

Think of one decision from this week where two important needs pulled you in different directions. What made the choice difficult?

FACILITATE:

Allow 15 seconds of quiet reflection and invite one brief response. A staffing need, team member concern, or operational priority can work as an example. Keep names and identifying details out of the discussion.

SAY:

Keep that decision in mind. By the end, you will have a way to name the tension, consider the decision, and explain a next step your team can understand.

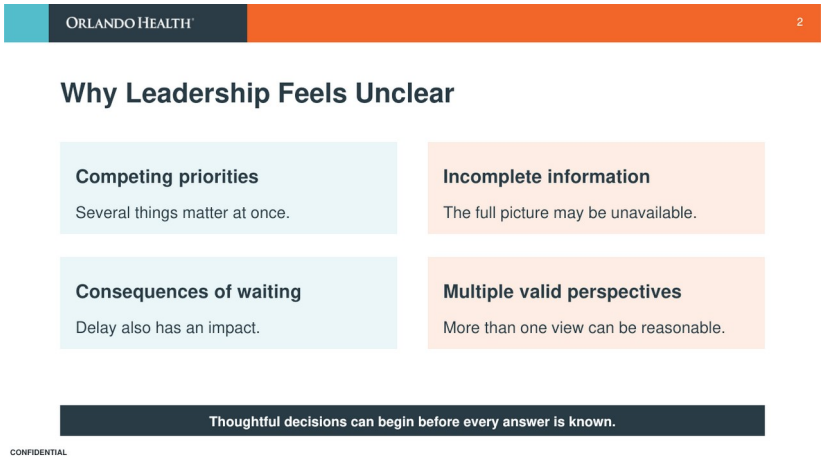
TRANSITION:

Let's look at why leadership decisions can feel unclear.

Leadership in the Gray

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Why Leadership Feels Unclear



TIMING: 1:20 | 1:00–2:20

SAY:

Many leadership challenges are not difficult because the answer is hidden. They're difficult because several things matter at the same time.

Leaders rarely receive complete information, unlimited time, and a perfect set of options all at once. We often wish we had more information before deciding. The challenge is that waiting also creates consequences. for the team waiting on an answer, and for the situation that keeps moving while we deliberate.

And often, more than one perspective is genuinely valid. Two experienced leaders can look at the same situation and reach different, defensible conclusions.

So the goal is not certainty. The goal is thoughtful decision-making.

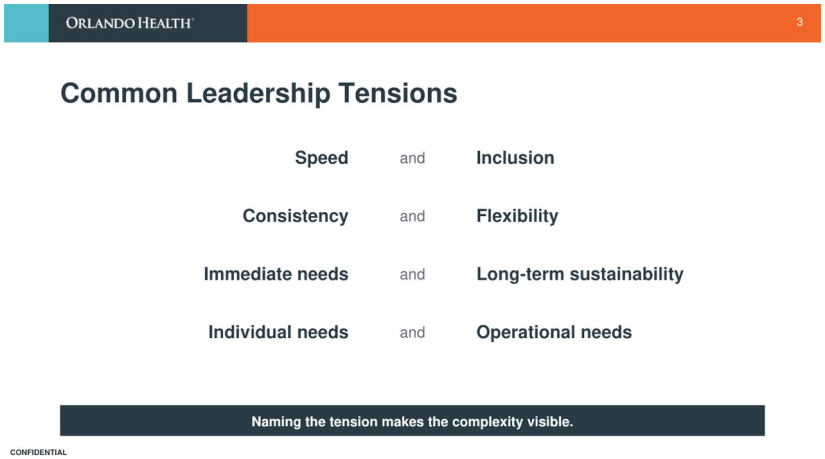
TRANSITION:

Most gray-area decisions share a common characteristic. multiple priorities are competing.

Leadership in the Gray

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Common Leadership Tensions



TIMING: 1:15 | 2:20–3:35

SAY:

Many difficult decisions involve two priorities that both matter. We may want to move quickly while still involving the people affected. We may value consistency across the team while recognizing that an individual situation may call for flexibility. We may need to meet an immediate staffing need while protecting the long-term sustainability of the schedule. We may want to support a team member while also meeting operational expectations.

Notice that in each pair, neither side is wrong. That is precisely what creates the gray area. If one option were clearly better, the decision would already be made.

Recognizing the tension does not solve the issue, but it does something important: it helps you understand what makes the decision difficult, which is the first step toward explaining it to others.

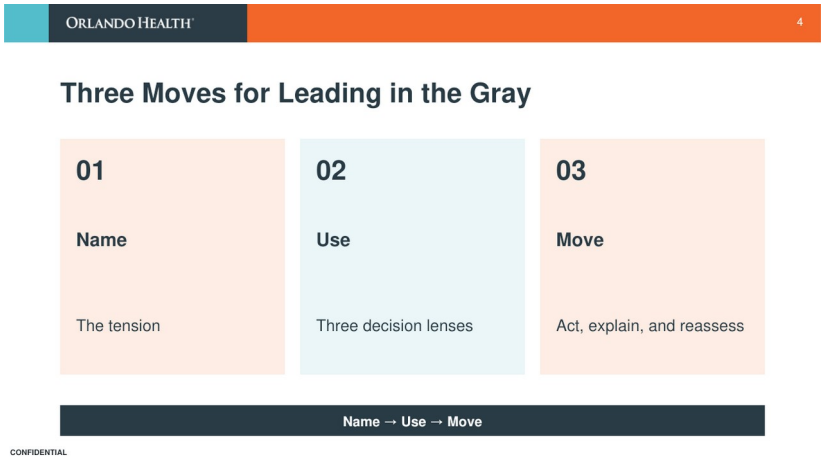
TRANSITION:

Once we identify the tension, we can use a process to work through it.

Leadership in the Gray

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Three Moves for Leading in the Gray



TIMING: 1:25 | 3:35–5:00

SAY:

When a situation feels unclear, three moves can help create clarity.

The three moves are Name, Use, and Move. Name the tension by identifying what is competing. Use three decision lenses to consider the situation. Move by making a responsible decision, explaining your reasoning, and setting a point to reassess.

These three moves won't remove the difficulty, but they give you a repeatable structure. And a structure is what allows you to make a decision under pressure without defaulting to whoever spoke last or loudest.

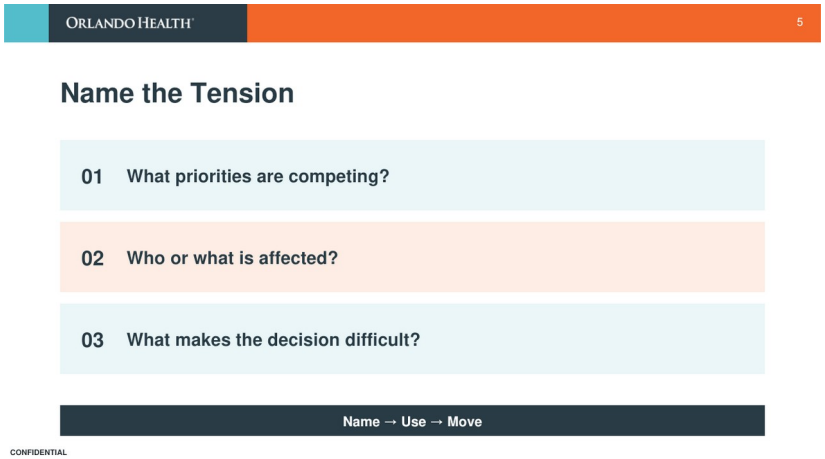
TRANSITION:

Let's look more closely at the first move.

Leadership in the Gray

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Name the Tension



TIMING: 1:25 | 5:00–6:25

SAY:

The first move is to name the tension, and it is worth slowing down to define exactly what makes the choice difficult.

Be specific about what is competing. Speed versus inclusion. Consistency versus flexibility. Immediate staffing needs versus long-term sustainability. Individual preferences versus operational requirements.

Then ask who or what is affected. patients, team members, and operations often carry different parts of the impact. And finally, ask what actually makes this difficult, and say that out loud.

Naming the tension demonstrates that multiple needs have been considered. It helps people understand the complexity of the decision rather than assuming the choice was simple and you chose wrong.

FACILITATOR TIP:

Frame the decision as “both matter” when two legitimate priorities compete. Clear safety, policy, or conduct requirements still apply. Naming a tension does not make every possible response equally acceptable.

REINFORCE:

Name. Use. Move. We have named the tension. Next, use the three lenses.

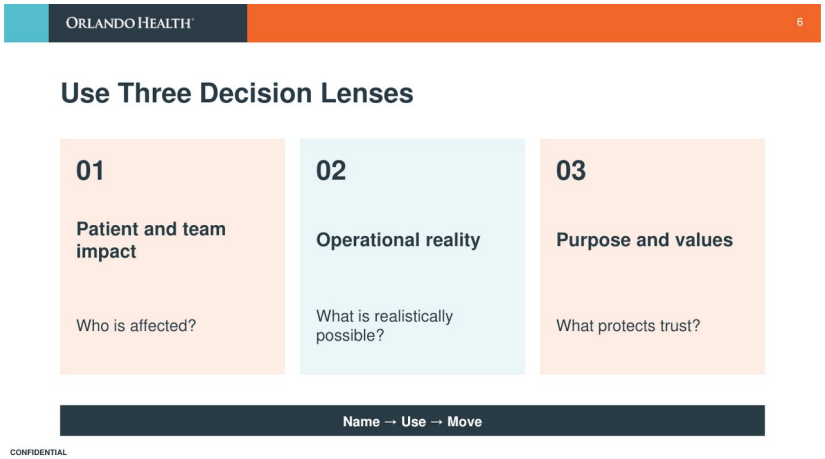
TRANSITION:

Once the tension is identified, it helps to evaluate the decision from several perspectives.

Leadership in the Gray

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Use Three Decision Lenses



TIMING: 1:25 | 6:25–7:50

SAY:

The second move is to evaluate the situation through three decision lenses.

The first lens is patient and team impact. How will this affect the people we serve? How will it affect the people doing the work? Could there be unintended consequences we haven't considered?

The second lens is operational reality. What is realistically possible? What limitations must be considered. staffing, budget, time, regulation? And what are the consequences of acting, or of not acting?

The third lens is alignment with purpose and values. Which option aligns with what we say matters? Which choice could we explain openly and confidently, to our team and to our leaders? Which decision best protects trust?

Using all three keeps us from over-weighting a single factor. usually the loudest or the most immediate one.

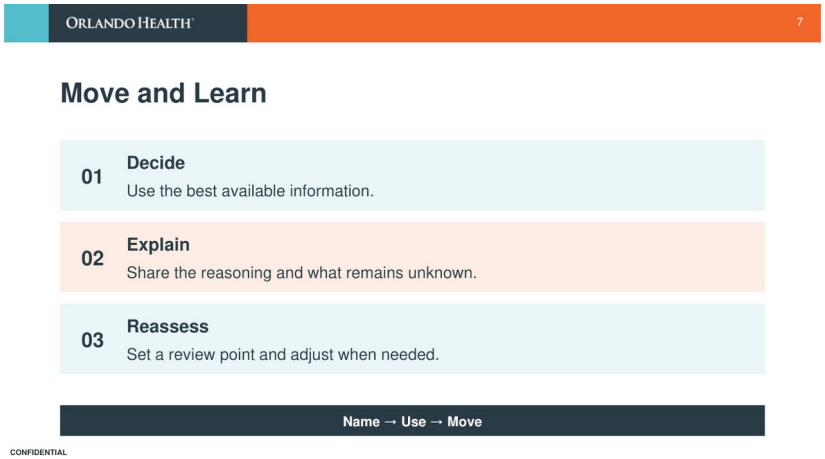
TRANSITION:

We have named the tension and used the lenses. Now we need to move and learn.

Leadership in the Gray

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Move and Learn



TIMING: 1:25 | 7:50–9:15

SAY:

Leadership in the gray does not mean waiting indefinitely.

At some point, leaders must make the best decision possible with the information available. That doesn't mean the decision is perfect. It means the decision is responsible based on what is known today.

Next, explain the reasoning behind the decision. People may not always agree with a decision, but they are more likely to trust the process when they understand how the decision was reached.

Finally, remain willing to reassess as new information becomes available. Adjusting a decision is not necessarily indecisiveness. Sometimes it is responsible leadership.

Decide, explain, and reassess are parts of the Move step. Set a specific review point so the decision does not drift.

FACILITATOR TIP:

Adjusting with new information can be responsible leadership. Keep repeating the same framework: Name. Use. Move.

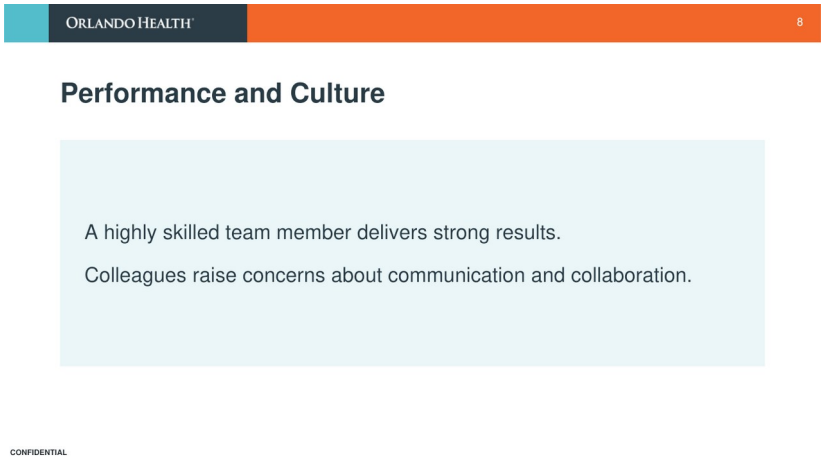
TRANSITION:

Let's apply all three moves to a realistic situation.

Leadership in the Gray

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Performance and Culture



TIMING: 2:15 | 9:15–11:30

SAY:

Imagine a team member who consistently delivers strong results and is trusted for expertise. Several colleagues have also raised concerns about communication and collaboration. Addressing the behavior may create discomfort. Leaving it unaddressed can affect trust and teamwork. Strong performance and respectful collaboration are both expectations.

ASK:

Using Name, Use, and Move, what would you do next?

FACILITATE:

Give 20 seconds to think, then take two brief responses. Keep the discussion focused on the leadership process rather than diagnosing the person. Allow about 45 seconds for responses.

DEBRIEF:

Name the tension: maintaining strong individual performance while addressing the impact on the team.

Use the lenses: consider patient and team impact, what is operationally realistic, and alignment with purpose and values. Gather specific examples rather than relying on labels.

Move: plan a timely, private conversation about the observed behavior, clarify expectations and support, and set a follow-up point. Follow applicable organizational processes.

FACILITATOR TIP:

Recognition of strong results does not excuse behavior that undermines collaboration. The framework helps leaders choose and explain a responsible response.

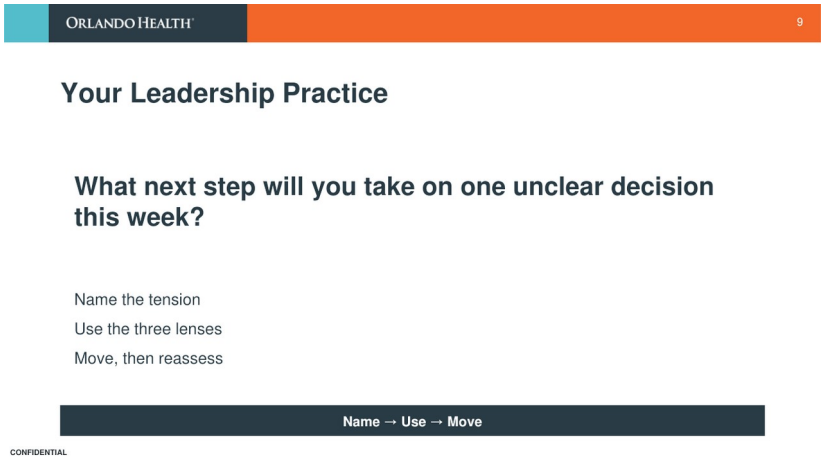
TRANSITION:

Now return to the decision you identified at the beginning.

Leadership in the Gray

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Your Leadership Practice



TIMING: 1:30 | 11:30–13:00

SAY:

Return to one decision you are currently facing. What priorities are in tension? What information is essential before you can act, and what would simply be helpful? What is your next responsible step, and when will you reassess?

ASK:

What one step will you take this week to make your decision process clearer to the people affected?

CHAT ENGAGEMENT:

Allow 15 seconds of reflection. Ask participants to share one action in the chat, or invite a brief verbal response in person. Pause 20 to 30 seconds, then acknowledge two responses.

CLOSE:

Remember Name, Use, and Move. Name the tension. Use the three lenses. Move responsibly, explain your thinking, and reassess. Confidence can come from creating clarity about the next step. Thank you for being here.